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AI reading list

32 titles selected for the library's AI display, from the shelf on the first floor of the Robert Crown Law Library. Every book is held by Stanford Libraries, and every entry below links to its SearchWorks record.

HOW TO USE THIS LIST

Each title links to Stanford's catalogue, where you can check availability, place a hold, or open the ebook. Reading a book about AI is not the same as being authorised to use AI for coursework: check your course policy first.

The shelf

1. The Digitalist Papers

Erik Brynjolfsson et al.

Stanford Digital Economy Lab · September 2024 · ISBN 9798991279307

Modelled on America's founding Federalist Papers, this policy essay series convenes experts from economics, law, technology, and political science to reimagine governance in the age of AI. Volume 1 explores how artificial intelligence intersects with democracy.

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2. Co-Intelligence: Living and Working with AI

Ethan Mollick

Portfolio · April 2024 · ISBN 9780593716717

An instant New York Times bestseller from Wharton's leading voice on AI, offering a practical playbook for working, learning, and living alongside generative AI. Mollick urges readers to engage with AI as co-worker, co-teacher, and coach.

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3. The Emergent Mind: How Intelligence Arises in People and Machines

Gaurav Suri and Jay McClelland

Basic Books · October 2025 · ISBN 9781541605282

Explores how human and artificial minds work through neural networks, asking fundamental questions about the nature of intelligence itself, and illuminating the parallels between biological and digital cognition.

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4. The Worlds I See: Curiosity, Exploration, and Discovery at the Dawn of AI

Fei-Fei Li

Flatiron Books · November 2023 · ISBN 9781250897930

A Financial Times Best Book of 2023 and one of Barack Obama's recommended books on AI. Dr. Li chronicles her creation of ImageNet, the dataset that catalysed modern deep learning, while advocating for a human-centered, ethical approach.

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5. AI Ethics: A Textbook

Paula Boddington

Springer · April 2024 · ISBN 9789811993848

Bridges theory and practice across the ethical challenges of artificial intelligence, from philosophical foundations to practical controversies in work, superintelligence, and moral machines.

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6. AI Snake Oil: What Artificial Intelligence Can Do, What It Can't, and How to Tell the Difference

Arvind Narayanan and Sayash Kapoor

Princeton University Press · September 2024 · ISBN 9780691249131

From two of TIME's 100 Most Influential People in AI, an essential guide for separating AI hype from reality — why much of predictive AI is snake oil, with nuanced analysis of generative AI's genuine potential.

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7. The AI Con: How to Fight Big Tech's Hype and Create the Future We Want

Emily M. Bender and Alex Hanna

Harper · May 2025 · ISBN 9780063418561

A sharp, accessible takedown of artificial intelligence hype. Known for their influential Stochastic Parrots paper, Bender and Hanna expose how tech corporations use AI narratives to justify data theft, surveillance, and labour devaluation.

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8. Empire of AI: Dreams and Nightmares in Sam Altman's OpenAI

Karen Hao

Penguin Press · May 2025 · ISBN 9780593657508

An instant New York Times bestseller and National Book Critics Circle Award finalist. Drawing on 300+ interviews and seven years of reporting, Hao investigates the company at the centre of the AI revolution.

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9. AI Valley: Microsoft, Google, and the Trillion-Dollar Race to Cash In on Artificial Intelligence

Gary Rivlin

Harper Business · March 2025 · ISBN 9780063347496

Pulitzer Prize-winning investigative journalist Rivlin embeds with Silicon Valley's top AI players during the post-ChatGPT era, following Reid Hoffman, Sam Altman, and Mustafa Suleyman as startups and tech giants collide.

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10. AI Superpowers: China, Silicon Valley, and the New World Order

Kai-Fu Lee

Houghton Mifflin Harcourt · September 2018 · ISBN 9781328546395

A prescient analysis of the US–China AI competition from one of the world's foremost AI pioneers, with a clear-eyed assessment of which jobs will be affected and a blueprint for human coexistence with AI.

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11. A Brief History of Intelligence: Evolution, AI, and the Five Breakthroughs That Made Our Brains

Max Bennett

Mariner Books · October 2023 · ISBN 9780063286344

Bridges neuroscience and artificial intelligence to ask why AI can beat grandmasters at chess but can't load a dishwasher, chronicling the brain's billion-year evolution through five key breakthroughs.

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12. Why Machines Learn: The Elegant Math Behind Modern AI

Anil Ananthaswamy

Dutton · July 2024 · ISBN 9780593185742

Demystifies the mathematical foundations powering today's AI, from 17th-century calculus and linear algebra to modern deep learning architectures, weaving in the history of machine learning's pioneers.

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13. Teaching with AI: A Practical Guide to a New Era of Human Learning

José Antonio Bowen and C. Edward Watson

Johns Hopkins University Press · April 2024 · ISBN 9781421449227

Research-backed strategies for harnessing AI as a teaching tool while navigating academic integrity, cheating, and the transformation of creativity and authorship.

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14. The Alignment Problem: Machine Learning and Human Values

Brian Christian

W. W. Norton & Company · October 2020 · ISBN 9780393635829

Explores the fundamental challenge of building AI systems that do what we actually want, examining how algorithms inherit our biases and make consequential decisions about bail, mortgages, and employment.

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15. Nexus: A Brief History of Information Networks from the Stone Age to AI

Yuval Noah Harari

Random House · September 2024 · ISBN 9780593734223

A #1 New York Times bestseller tracing how information networks — from oral traditions and sacred texts to bureaucracies and AI — have shaped human societies, and the urgent choices we now face.

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16. The Cambridge Handbook of the Law, Ethics and Policy of Artificial Intelligence

Nathalie A. Smuha (ed.)

Cambridge University Press · February 2025 · ISBN 9781009367813

An interdisciplinary handbook on AI's legal, ethical, and policy implications, with particular focus on European frameworks including the EU AI Act, covering healthcare, finance, education, media, labour, and law enforcement.

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17. AI and the Legal Profession: Transforming the Future of Law (Second Edition)

Francesca Ramadan (ed.)

Globe Law and Business · June 2025 · ISBN 9781837230884

A guide for legal professionals navigating AI in practice: how it is changing legal research, document review, and predictive analytics, and the concerns about ethics, privacy, and algorithmic bias.

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18. The Singularity Is Nearer: When We Merge with AI

Ray Kurzweil

Viking · June 2024 · ISBN 9780399562761

The long-awaited sequel to *The Singularity Is Near*, reaffirming Kurzweil's predictions that AI will reach human-level intelligence by 2029 and that humans will merge with machines by 2045.

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19. How To Think About AI: A Guide for the Perplexed

Richard Susskind

Oxford University Press · March 2025 · ISBN 9780198941927

Drawing on four decades in artificial intelligence, the legal technology pioneer offers an accessible, balanced guide — equipping readers with the frameworks and vocabulary to think critically about AI rather than handing them answers.

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20. The Optimist: Sam Altman, OpenAI, and the Race to Invent the Future

Keach Hagey

W. W. Norton & Company · May 2025 · ISBN 9781324075967

The first major biography of Sam Altman, based on more than 250 interviews including extensive time with Altman himself, charting his rise from St. Louis through Y Combinator to building OpenAI.

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21. The Thinking Machine: Jensen Huang, Nvidia, and the World's Most Coveted Microchip

Stephen Witt

Viking · April 2025 · ISBN 9780593832691

Through unprecedented access to Jensen Huang and Nvidia's inner circle, the story of how a video game chip company became the engine of the AI revolution — essential for understanding AI's hardware foundations.

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22. These Strange New Minds: How AI Learned to Talk and What It Means

Christopher Summerfield

Viking · March 2025 · ISBN 9780593831717

A neuroscientist and AI researcher weaves together cognitive science, linguistics, and philosophy to explain how large language models work, whether they can truly think, and what their emergence means.

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23. The Coming Wave: Technology, Power, and the Twenty-first Century's Greatest Dilemma

Mustafa Suleyman with Michael Bhaskar

Crown · September 2023 · ISBN 9780593593950

From a co-founder of DeepMind, an insider's warning about the dual-edged nature of transformative technologies: AI and synthetic biology will create unprecedented prosperity while threatening the foundations of the nation-state.

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24. Atlas of AI: Power, Politics, and the Planetary Costs of Artificial Intelligence

Kate Crawford

Yale University Press · April 2021 · ISBN 9780300209570

A landmark critical examination revealing AI as neither artificial nor particularly intelligent, but a technology of extraction — from lithium mines to underpaid data labellers to the surveillance apparatus.

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25. Brave New Words: How AI Will Revolutionize Education (and Why That's a Good Thing)

Salman Khan

Viking · May 2024 · ISBN 9780593656952

The founder of Khan Academy offers a hopeful yet realistic roadmap for teachers, parents, and students — how AI can personalise learning, adapt to individual needs, and democratise access to world-class tutoring.

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26. Searches: Selfhood in the Digital Age

Vauhini Vara

Pantheon · April 2025 · ISBN 9780593701522

A genre-defying blend of memoir, journalism, and experimental writing interrogating our relationship with technology through the lens of personal loss, from the Pulitzer finalist who asked a ChatGPT predecessor to help write about her sister's death.

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27. Digitalization and Artificial Intelligence in Courts: Opportunities and Challenges

Fernando Esteban de la Rosa et al. (eds.)

Oxford University Press · September 2025 · ISBN 9780198918721

How digitalisation and AI are transforming global justice systems, from online dispute resolution to the contested idea of AI judges, with rigorous analysis of algorithmic bias, data privacy, and cybersecurity.

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28. Shared Wisdom: Cultural Evolution in the Age of AI

Alex Pentland

MIT Press · November 2025 · ISBN 9780262050999

Pentland argues that humanity's greatest breakthroughs emerged not from individual genius but from cultural inventions that accelerated collective wisdom — and offers a framework for ensuring AI amplifies rather than replaces human deliberation.

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29. Generative AI and Libraries: Claiming Our Place in the Center of a Shared Future

Michael Hanegan and Chris Rosser

ALA Editions/Core · June 2025 · ISBN 9798892553100

Makes the case that libraries are uniquely positioned to lead AI's ethical and human-centered integration, with practical frameworks for evaluating AI tools and navigating ethical considerations.

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30. Power and Progress: Our Thousand-Year Struggle Over Technology and Prosperity

Daron Acemoglu and Simon Johnson

PublicAffairs · May 2023 · ISBN 9781541702530

Two Nobel Prize-winning MIT economists demonstrate that technological progress does not automatically benefit everyone — it depends on political, social, and economic choices — and offer a manifesto for redirecting innovation toward shared prosperity.

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31. The AI and Data Revolution: Understanding the New Data Landscape

Martin De Saulles

Facet Publishing · June 2025 · ISBN 9781783307081

How AI-driven innovations represent a step-change in how organisations extract value from data, tracing 30 years from mass media and the internet through mobile computing, social networks, and generative AI.

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32. New Horizons in Artificial Intelligence in Libraries

Edmund Balnaves et al. (eds.)

De Gruyter Saur · 2024 · ISBN 9783111336435

Explores developing library AI paradigms, including practical implementation and opportunities on the horizon, addressing ethics, transparency, scenario planning, and the implications of bias.

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